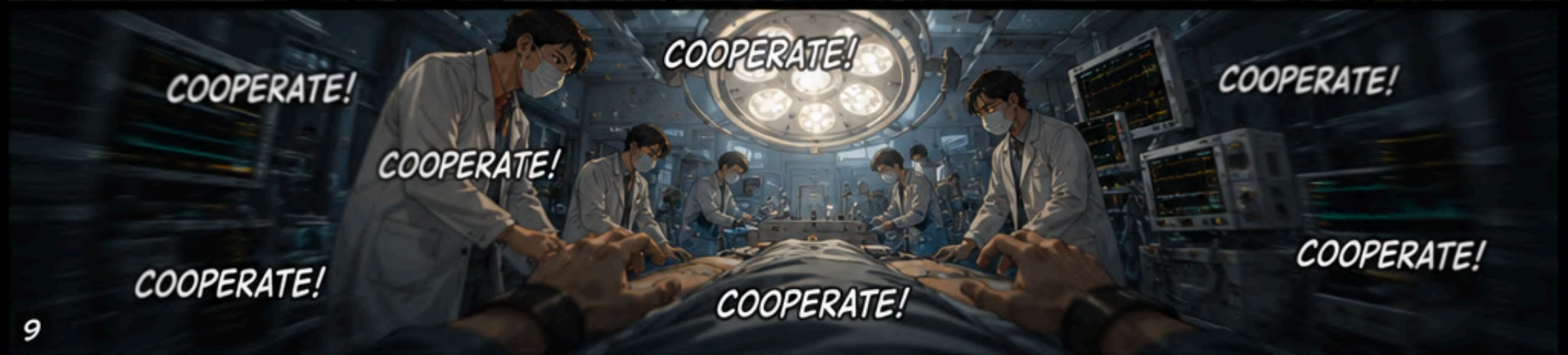


VOLUME-1

EPISODE-2 THE OTHER SIDE







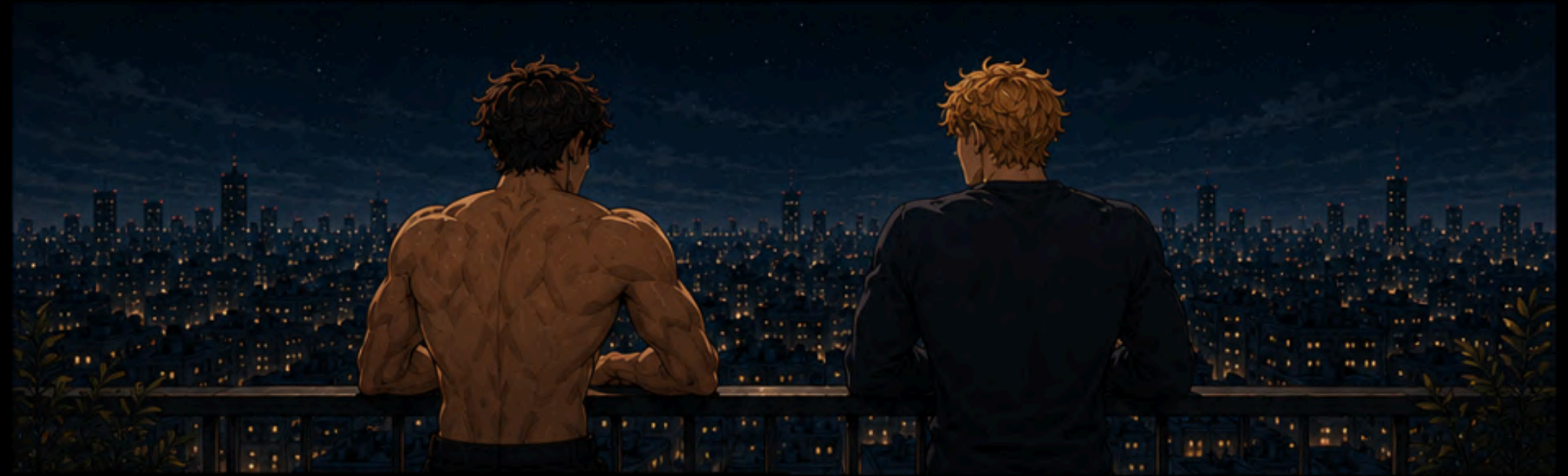
CAN'T
SLEEP,
HUH?



SAME
DREAM?

NO.

...



SILENCE
RETURNED.

AFTER A MOMENT,
HE SIMPLY
NODDED.

GOOD NIGHT,
BUDDY.

IT'S GOING TO BE
MORNING SOON.

HAHA.
GOOD NIGHT.

MORNING...

ALPHA, PRESIDENT TAYLOR
WANTS TO HOST ANOTHER
CEREMONY FOR THE NEW
RECRUITMENT. HE WANTS EVERY
MAJOR MEDIA OUTLET THERE
FOR A GRAND LAUNCH OF
ATOM GIRL.

DO YOU REALLY
THINK SHE'S
CAPABLE?

YES, DEFINITELY.
WHY DO YOU
ASK?

SHE WAS A KID,
QUEEN. YOU KNOW
WE'RE NOT ONLY
FACING SUPERVILLAINS
HERE.

YEAH, I KNOW.
SHE'LL LEARN, ALPHA,
LIKE THE REST OF US.
AND THE ANSWER SHE
GAVE ABOUT REPLACING
BELLY MAN WAS QUITE
GOOD. NOT THAT
IMPRESSIVE, BUT
IT WAS GOOD. SHE'LL
DO IT.

ALPHA.



QUEEN.
PLEASURE TO
MEET YOU BOTH
ONCE AGAIN.



WHY ARE YOU
HERE SUDDENLY?



WHY NOT? CAN'T I
COME TO MY OWN
HEADQUARTERS?

HE PAUSED AND
SMILED.

I'M KIDDING.



I SPOKE TO THE
PRESIDENT ABOUT THE
SUPERHUMAN MILITARY
PROJECT.

HE SAID, "WE'LL SEE
TO IT." THAT'S PRACTICALLY
A SUCCESS, ISN'T IT,
ALPHA?

JUST THINK ABOUT IT—
SUPERHUMANS PROTECTING
OUR BORDERS. NO COUNTRY
WOULD DARE OPPOSE US.

WHAT A WAY TO MAKE OUR
COUNTRY NUMBER
ONE.



USING
SUPERHEROES
AS WEAPONS IS
NOT A GOOD
THING, TAYLOR.



WEAPONS?
THEY'RE NOT
WEAPONS,
ALPHA.
THEY'RE OUR
GIFTS.



I DON'T
KNOW ABOUT
THAT, BUT—



DON'T THINK
ABOUT IT.
LEAVE IT.
WHEN THE TIME
COMES, YOU'LL
UNDERSTAND.



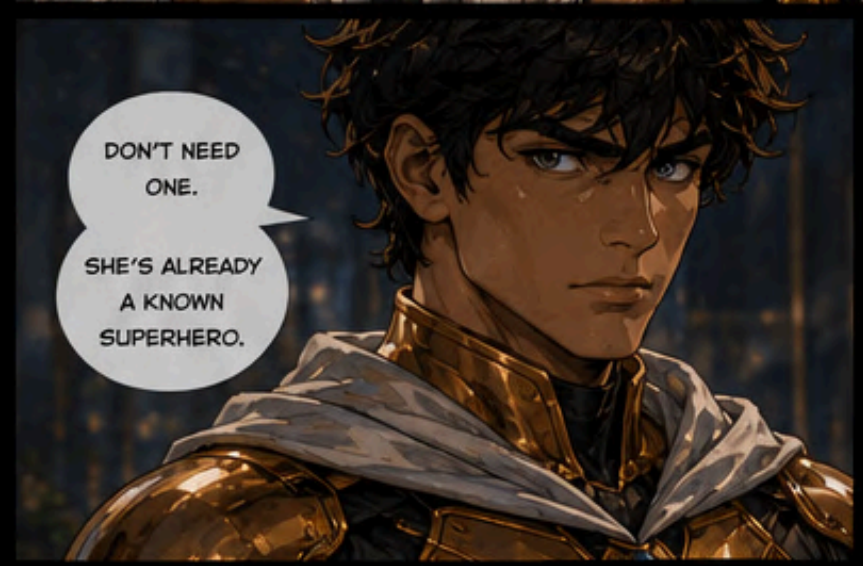
NOW, LET'S
CELEBRATE OUR
NEW RECRUIT.
WHERE IS
THE GIRL?



SHE'LL BE
HERE SOON.



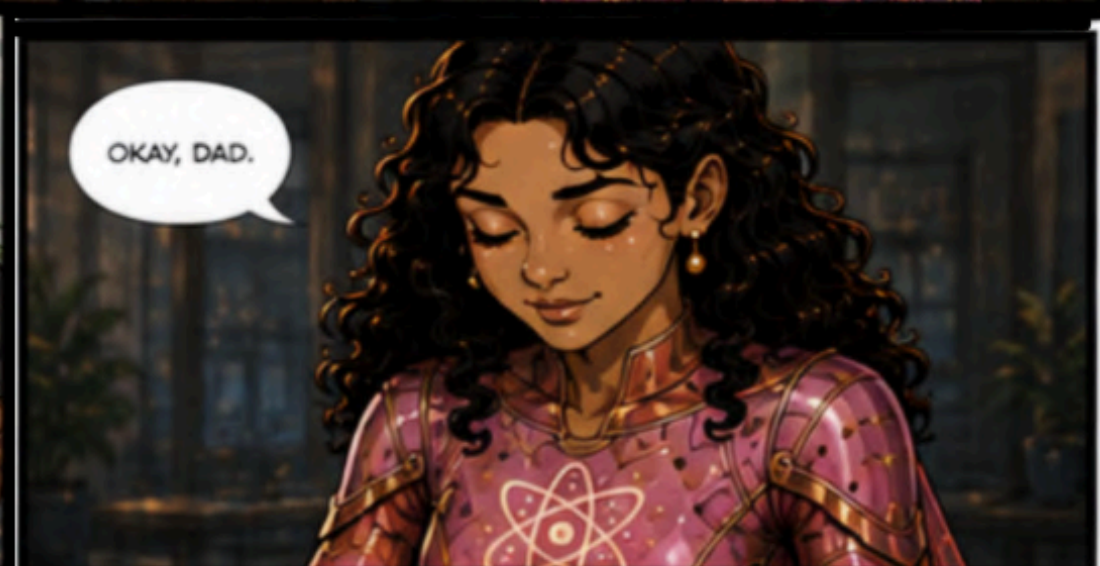
LET'S ARRANGE
AN INITIATION
CEREMONY FOR HER,
ALRIGHT?

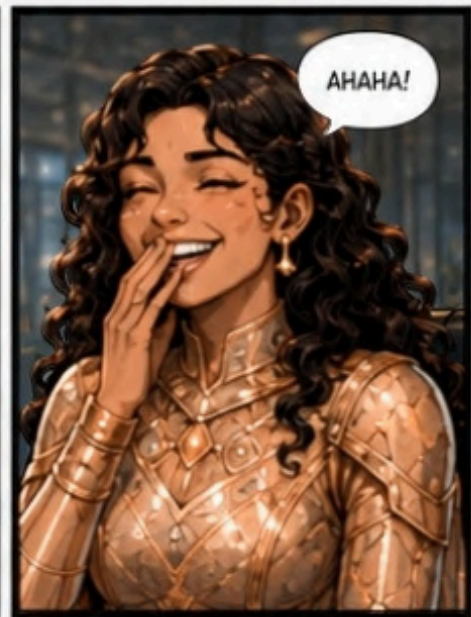


DON'T NEED
ONE.

SHE'S ALREADY
A KNOWN
SUPERHERO.







BEFORE WE MOVE ON,
THERE IS SOMETHING ELSE.
WE'VE RECEIVED SEVERAL
REPORTS FROM THE OUTSKIRTS
OF ASHTON, NEAR THE BORDER
OF THE DARK CITY.

PEOPLE HAVE BEEN SEEING
STRANGE LIGHTS AND
MOVEMENTS AROUND AN
ABANDONED INDUSTRIAL AREA
LATE AT NIGHT.

I WANT YOU TWO TO
INVESTIGATE IT.

GUARDIANS
SYNDICATE

WHAT IS THIS,
A GHOST STORY?

IF YOU'RE
SCARED, YOU
CAN STAY
HERE.

SCARED?
ME? NEVER.

IT'S NOT A GHOST.
FIND OUT WHAT'S
ACTUALLY HAPPENING
AND REPORT BACK.

DON'T ENGAGE UNLESS
YOU HAVE TO.

INVESTIGATION
WITH THE OLD
MAN? OKAY,
I'M IN.

...

GUARDIANS
SYNDICATE

NOW, ABOUT GLOW PLUG.
THE DAMAGE HE CAUSED
THE DAY BEFORE YESTERDAY
WAS MUCH GREATER THAN
ANYTHING WE'VE SEEN
FROM HIS PREVIOUS
ATTACKS.

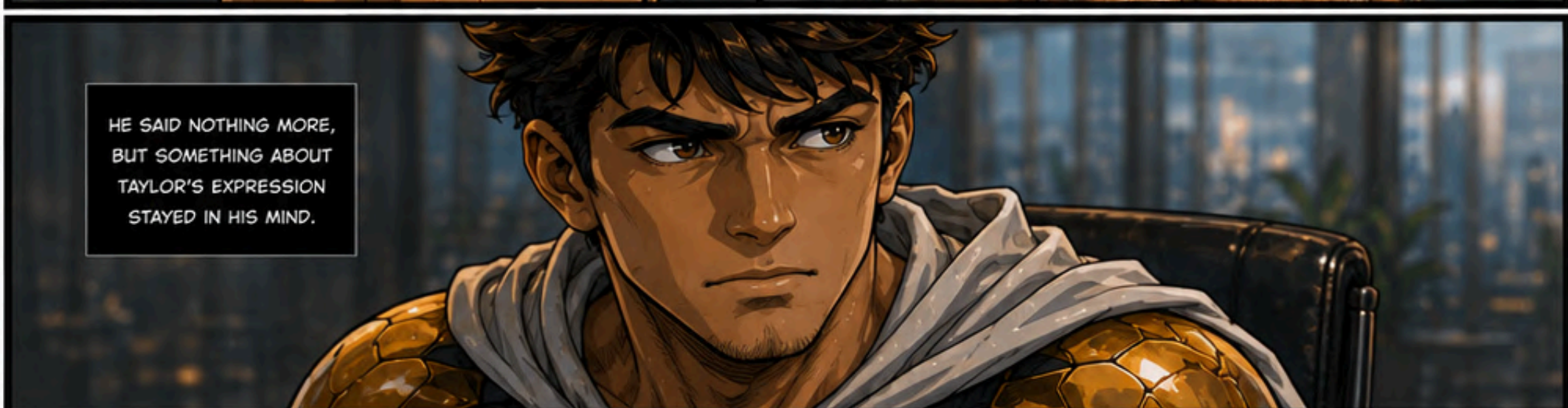
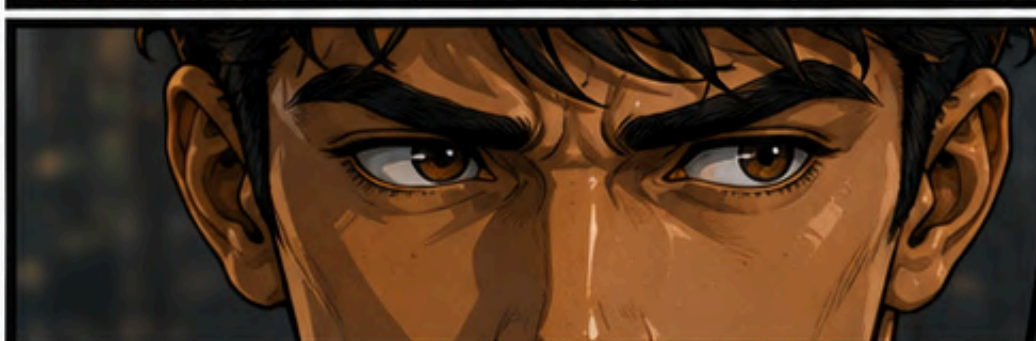
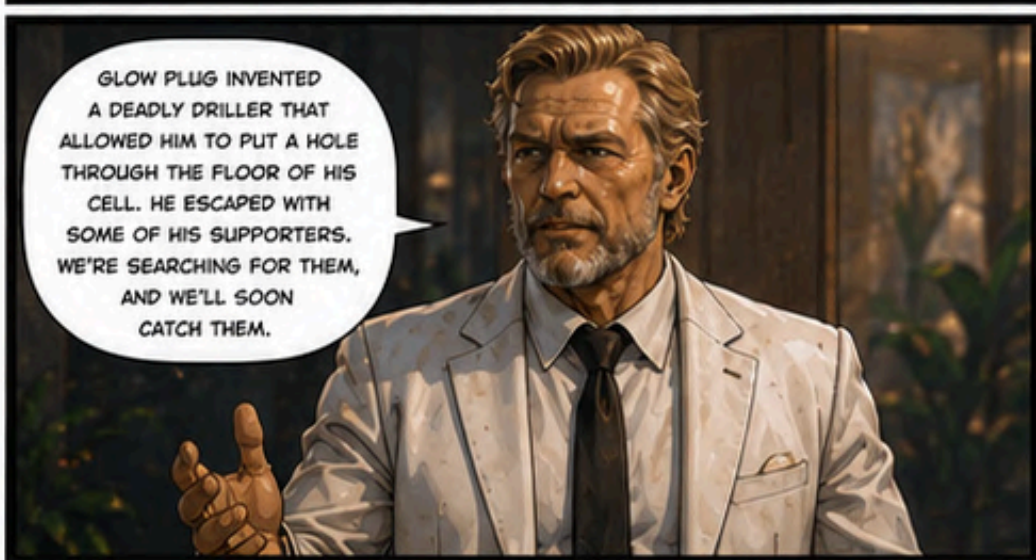
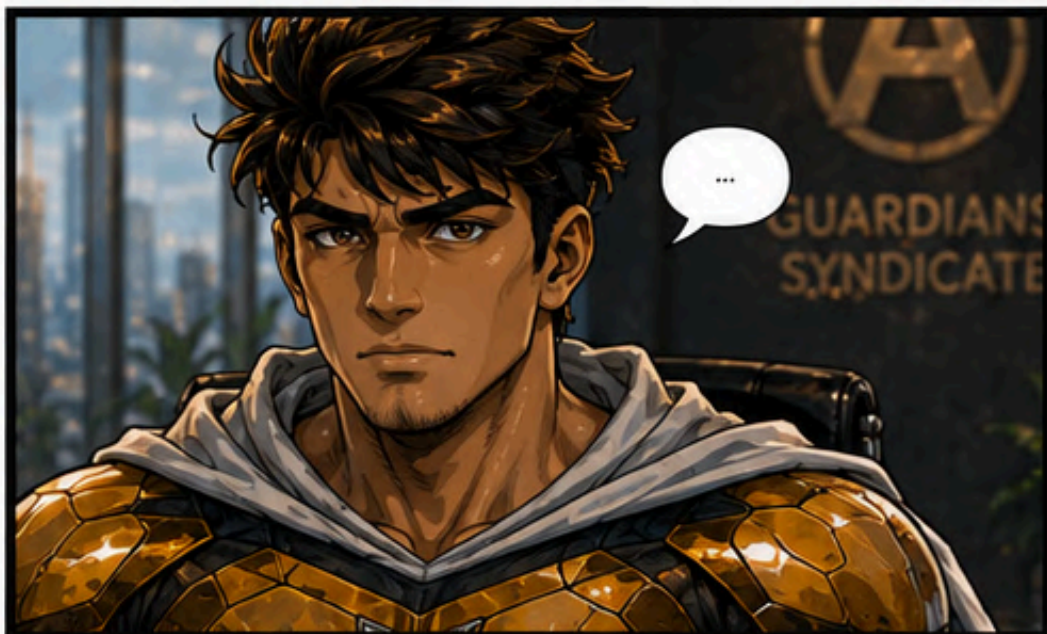
AT LEAST WE
SAVED EVERYONE.
THAT'S WHAT
MATTERS MORE,
RIGHT?

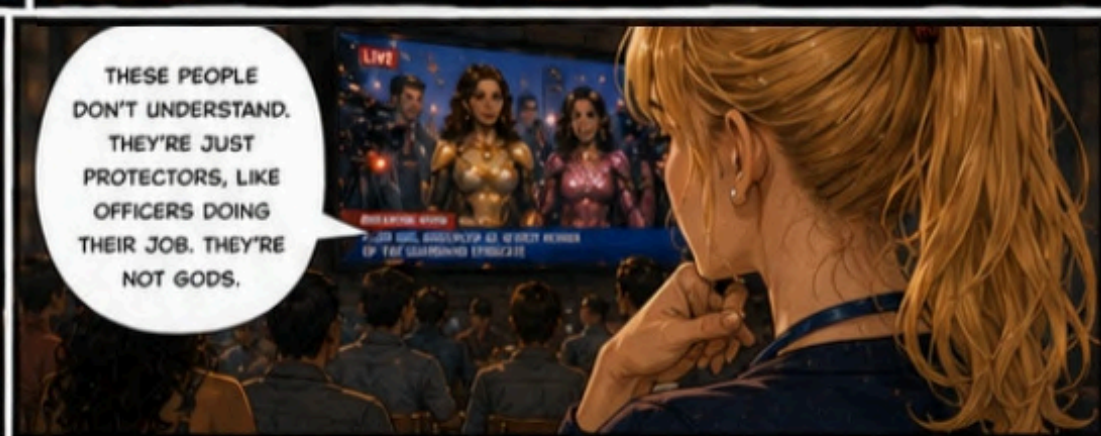
SAVING EVERYONE
MATTERS, BUT WE NEED
TO UNDERSTAND WHAT
HAPPENED.

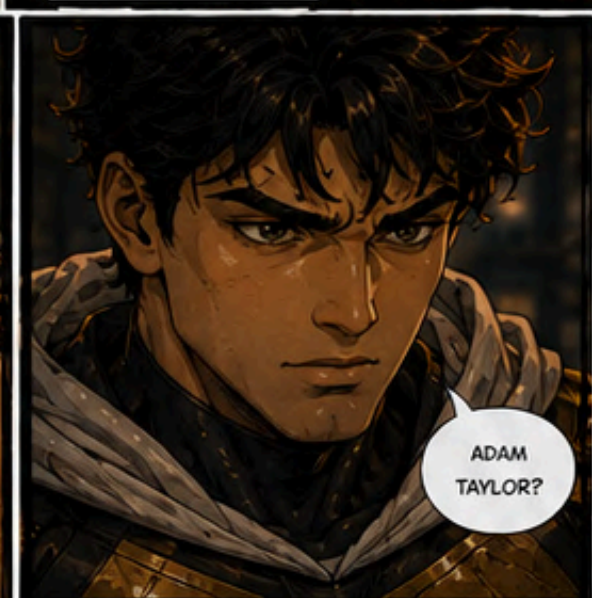
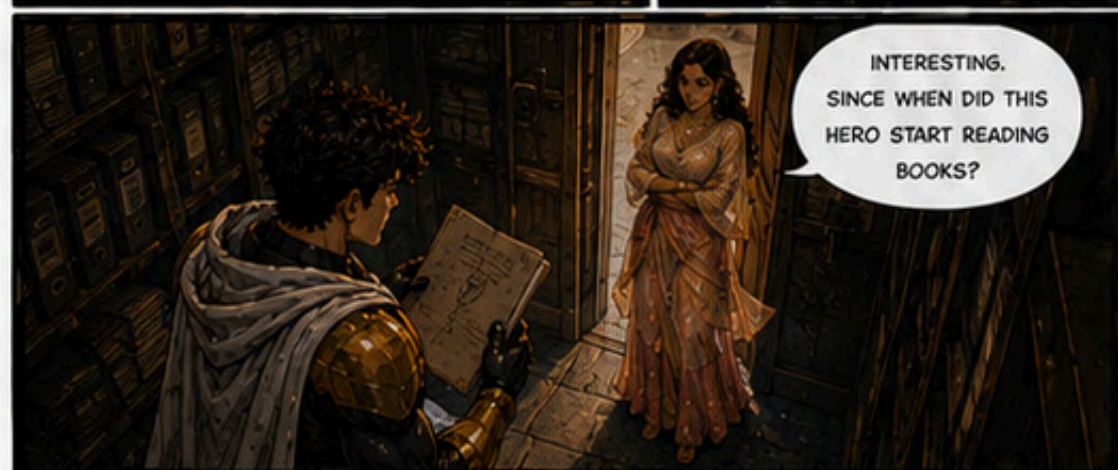
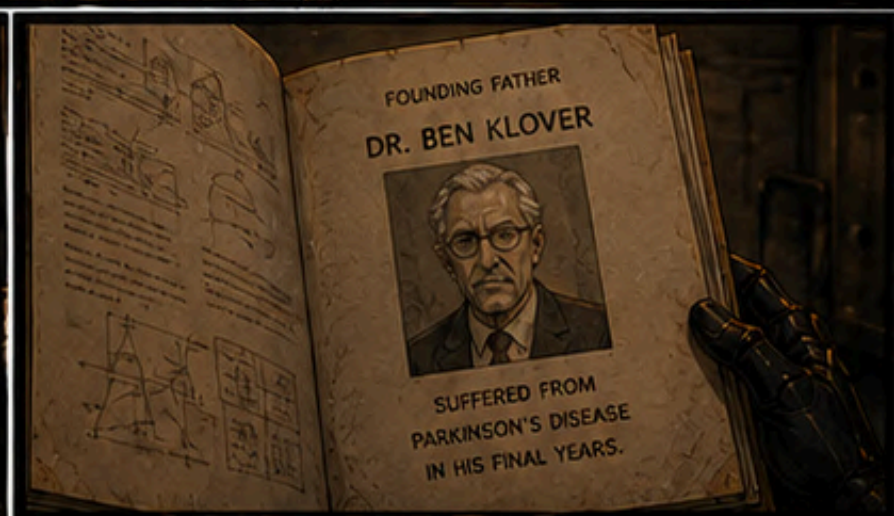
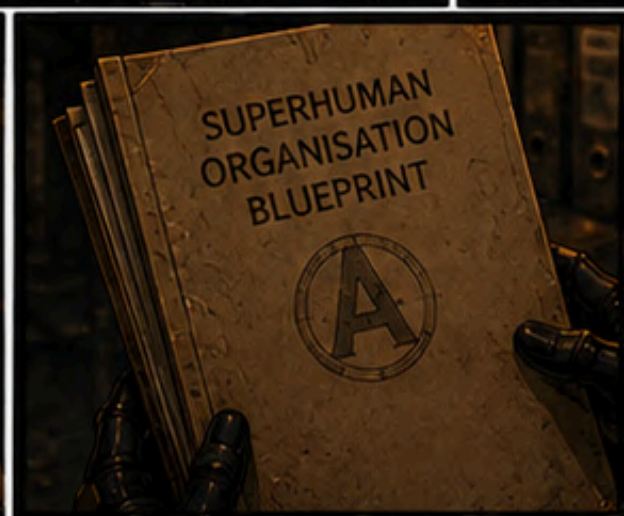
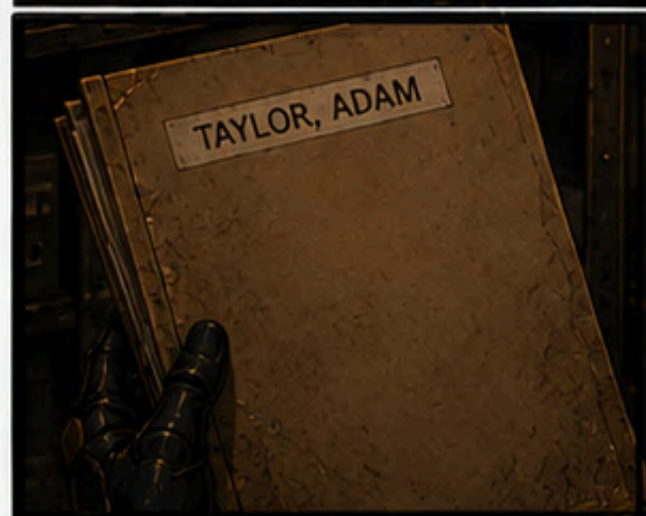
GLOW PLUG HAS STARTED
DEVELOPING HIGH-LEVEL
TECHNOLOGY SPECIFICALLY
DESIGNED AROUND OUR
WEAK POINTS. HE'S
STUDYING US AND
CREATING WEAPONS
ACCORDING TO WHAT HE
FINDS.

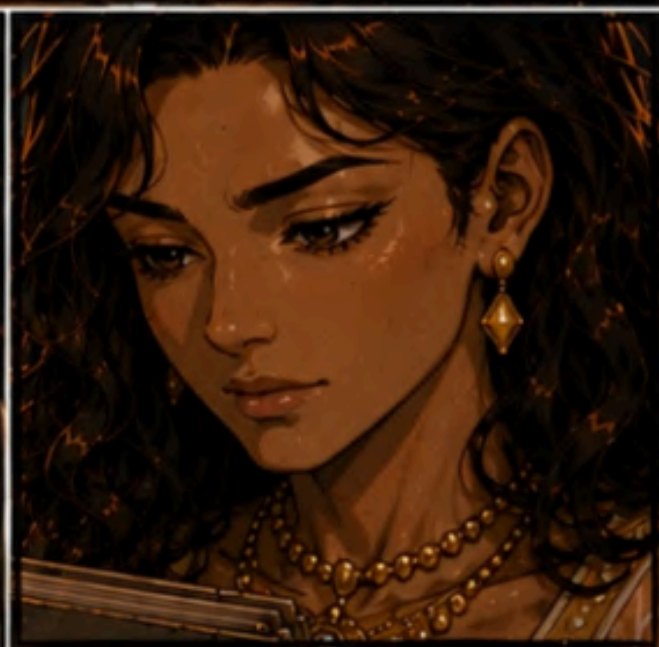
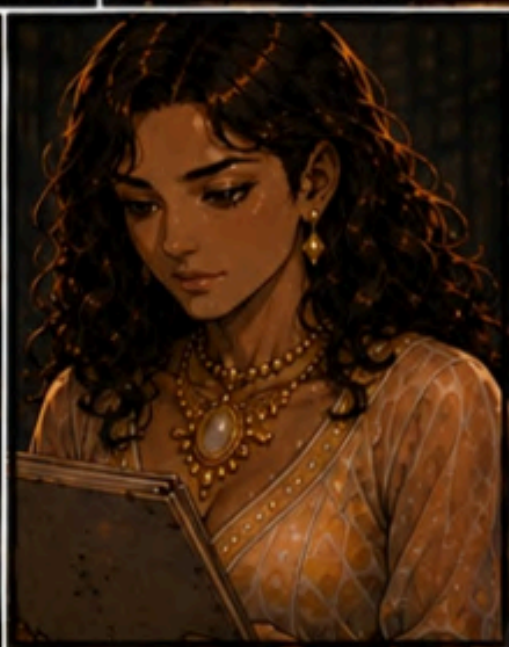
WE NEED TO KNOW WHAT
HE'S CAPABLE OF BEFORE
HIS NEXT ATTACK AND
NEUTRALIZE HIM.

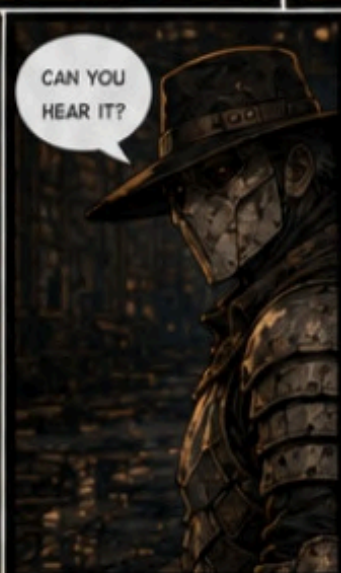
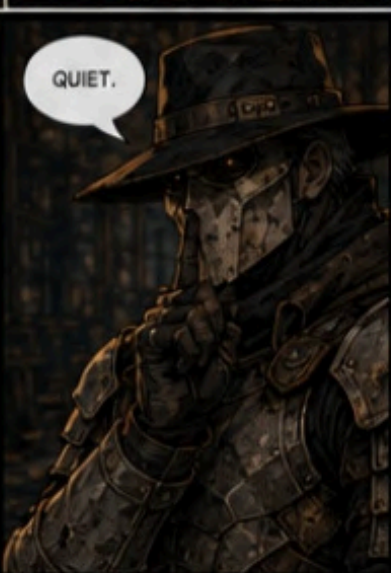
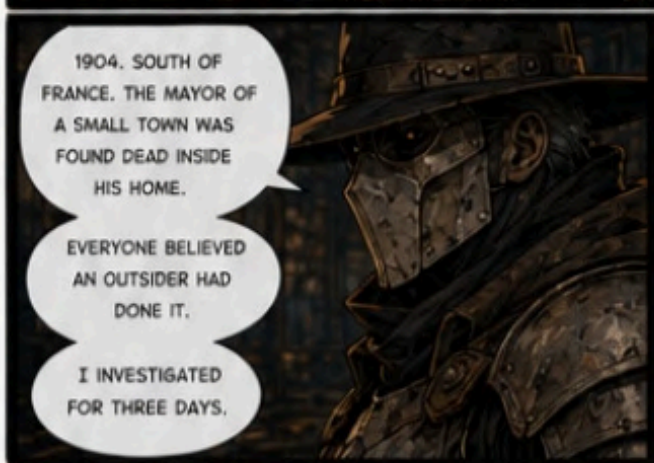
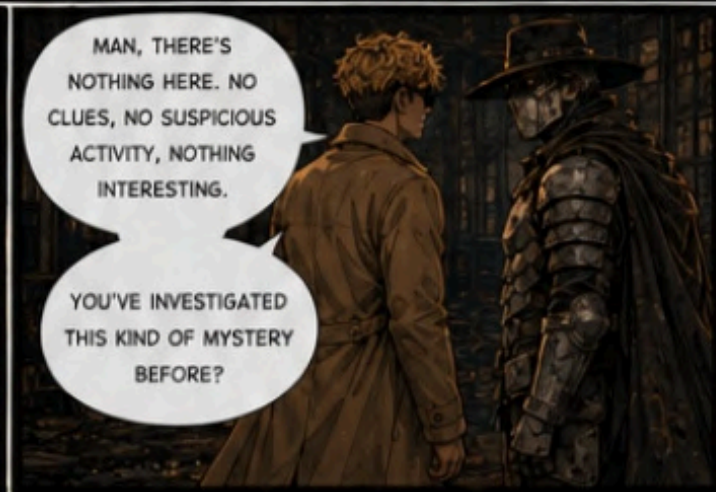
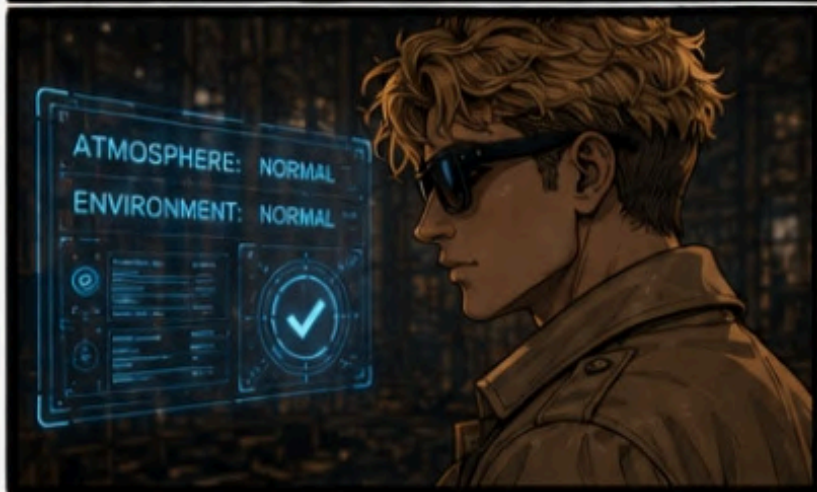
SORRY TO
INTERRUPT, BUT
HOW DID GLOW
PLUG ACTUALLY
ESCAPE IF THE
GUARDIANS
CAPTURED HIM SIX
TIMES ALREADY?

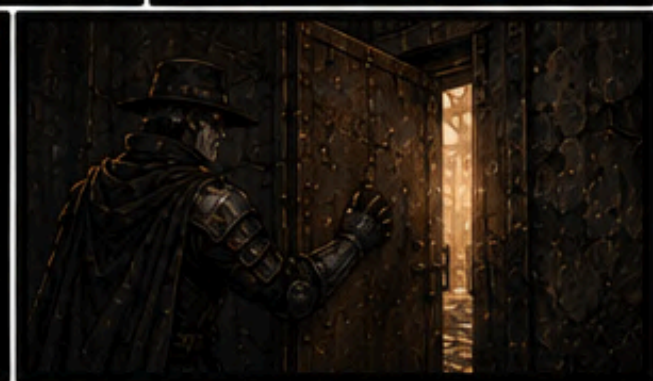
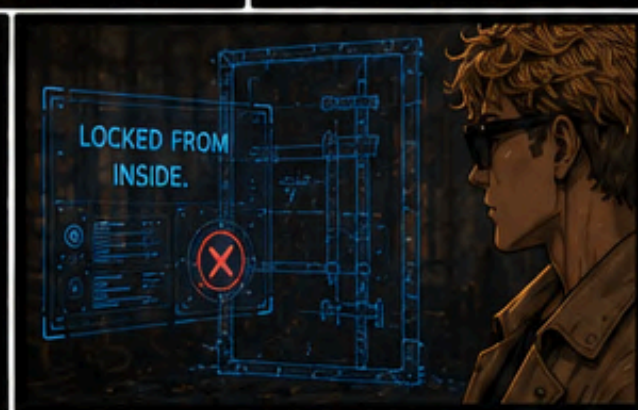












DARU RETURNED HOME AFTER HER FIRST DAY AT THE GUARDIANS SYNDICATE, STILL GLOWING WITH EXCITEMENT.

SHE SAT WITH HER MOTHER AND HAPPILY DESCRIBED EVERYTHING—THE WAY QUEEN WELCOMED HER, SHAPE SHIFTER'S PERSONALITY, RAMPAGE'S COLD SILENCE THAT HAD EMBARRASSED HER,

AND FINALLY ALPHA VOID.

AND THEN I SAW ALPHA VOID THIS CLOSE! MY GOD, MOM, HE LOOKS SO WELL BUILT! I COULD SEE HIS MUSCLES CLEARLY EVEN THROUGH THAT GOLDEN COSTUME!

BUT THE MOMENT HER FATHER ENTERED WITH A COUGH, DARU'S SMILE FADED.

WHY ARE YOU HERE? SHOULDN'T YOU BE AT HEADQUARTERS?

DON'T TAKE THIS AS ANOTHER JOB LIKE THE MUTANT TEENS, DARU. THIS IS A HUGE OPPORTUNITY. THERE WILL BE PLENTY OF WORK TO DO. DON'T GET EXCITED JUST BECAUSE YOU MET THOSE HEROES. YOU SHOULD BE EXCITED WHEN YOU BECOME LIKE ALPHA, NOT WHEN YOU'RE STANDING BESIDE HIM. TRAIN YOURSELF TO BE BETTER, DARU.

HER FATHER'S WORDS FINALLY BROKE SOMETHING INSIDE HER.

WHY, DAD? WHY CAN'T YOU APPRECIATE ME EVEN ONCE? WHAT DO YOU WANT ME TO DO ON MY FIRST DAY? GO TO THE DARK CITY, BRING EVERY VILLAIN TO THEIR KNEES, AND COME BACK WITH A GOOD NAME FOR THE GOVERNMENT? I DON'T WANT TO BE SOMEONE ELSE, DAD. I JUST WANT TO BE ME!

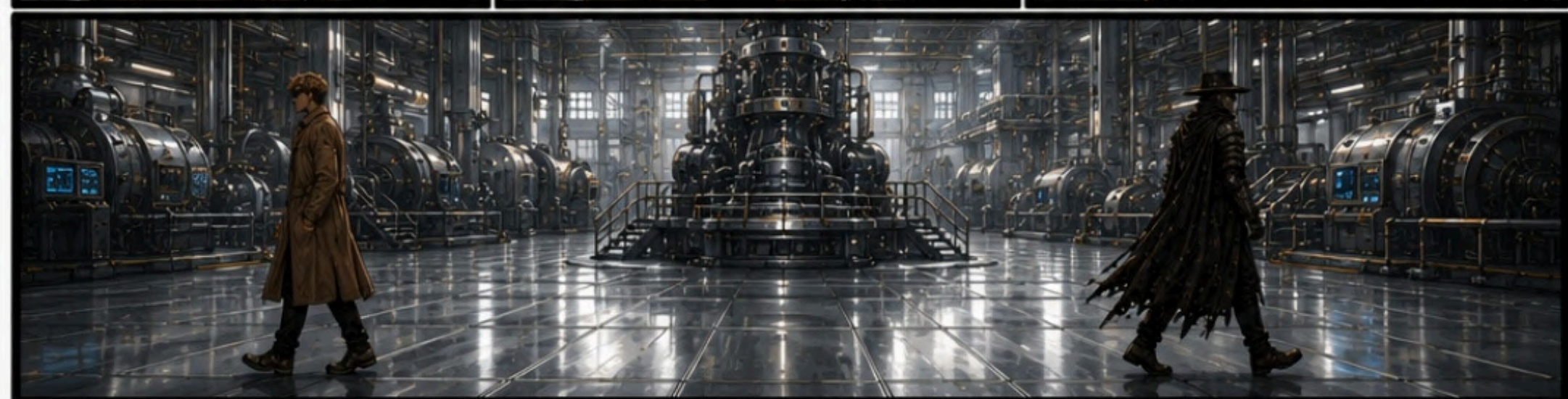
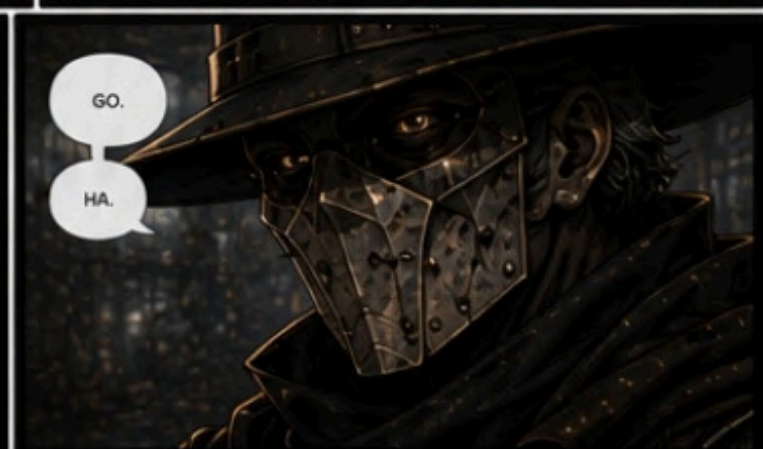
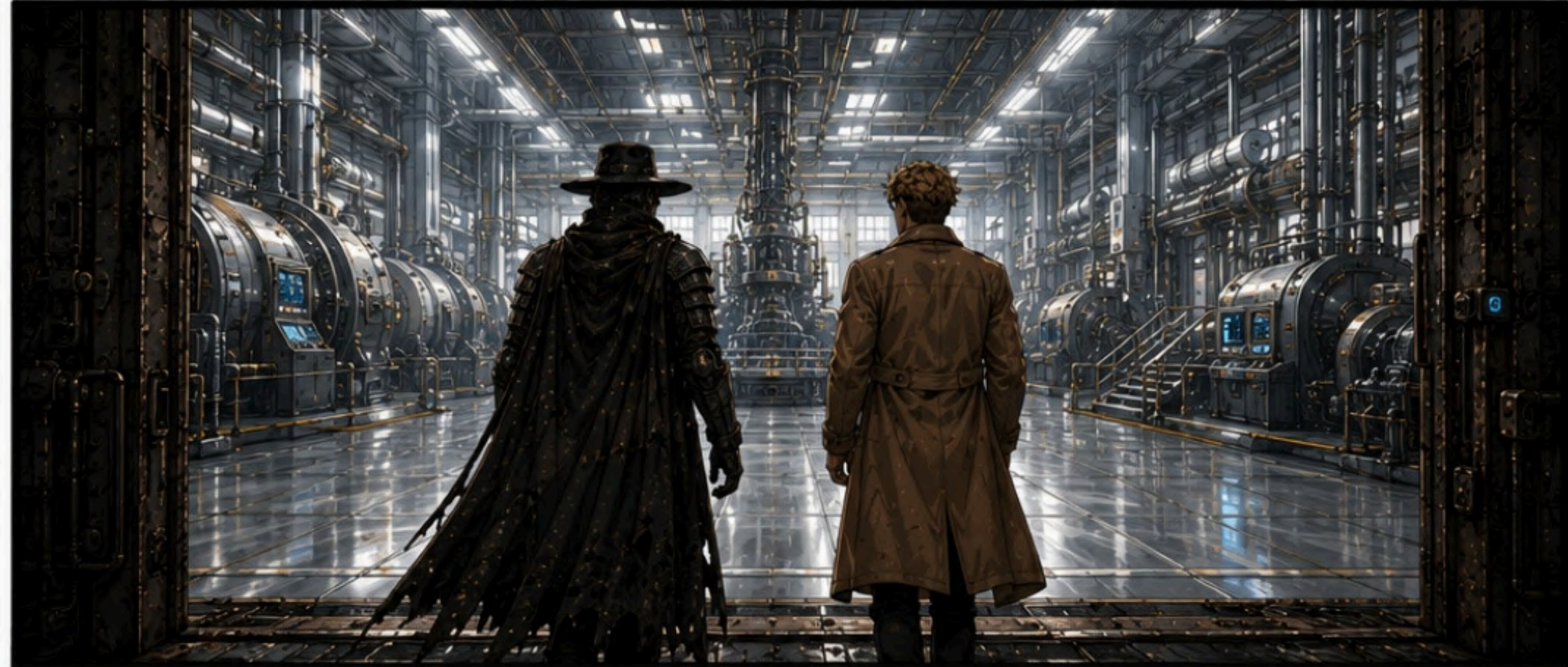
DID YOU EVEN ASK WHAT HAPPENED TODAY? NO. NOTHING. IT'S ALWAYS 'DARU, DO THIS. DARU, DO THAT.' WHY, DAD?

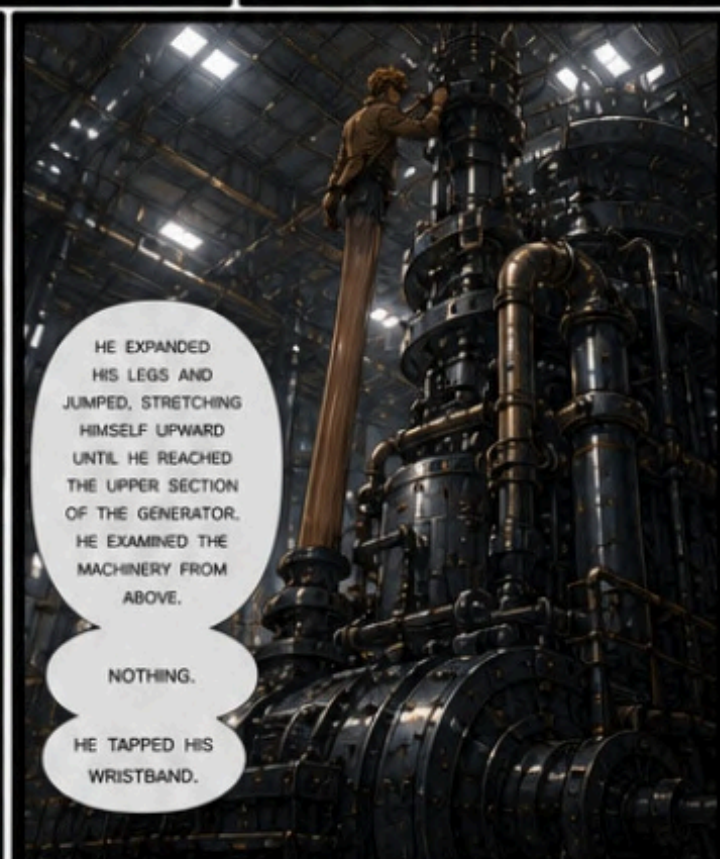
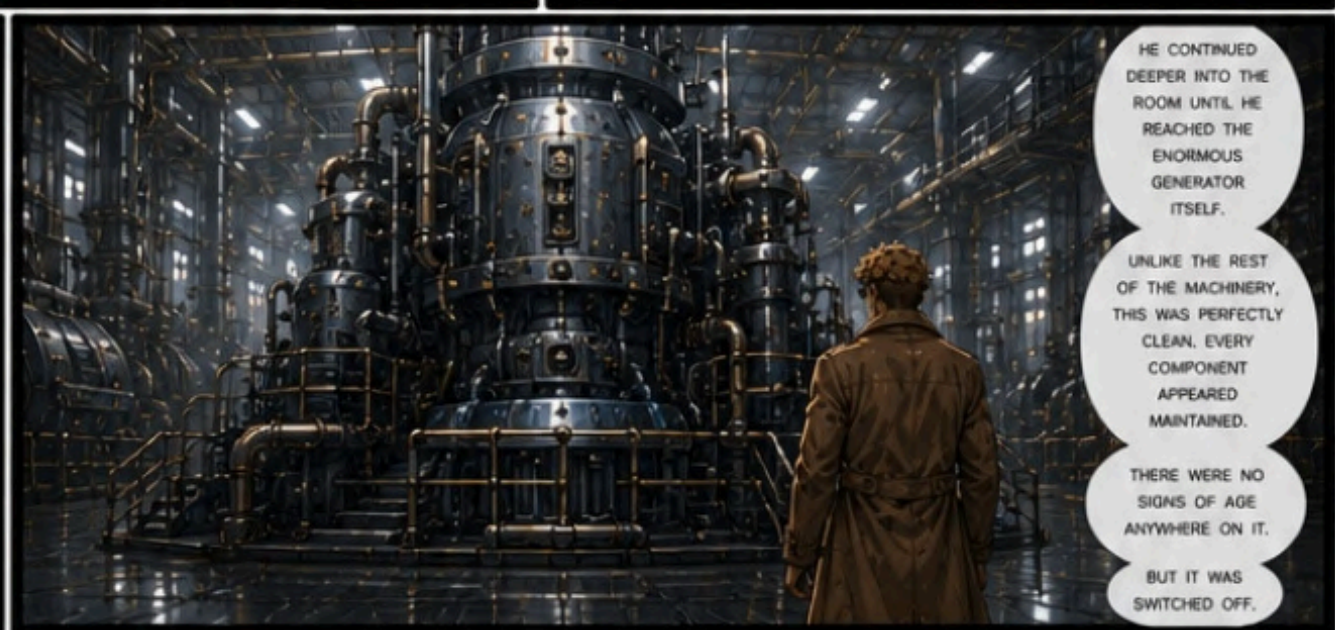
SHE WIPED HER TEARS AND TURNED TOWARD HER MOTHER.

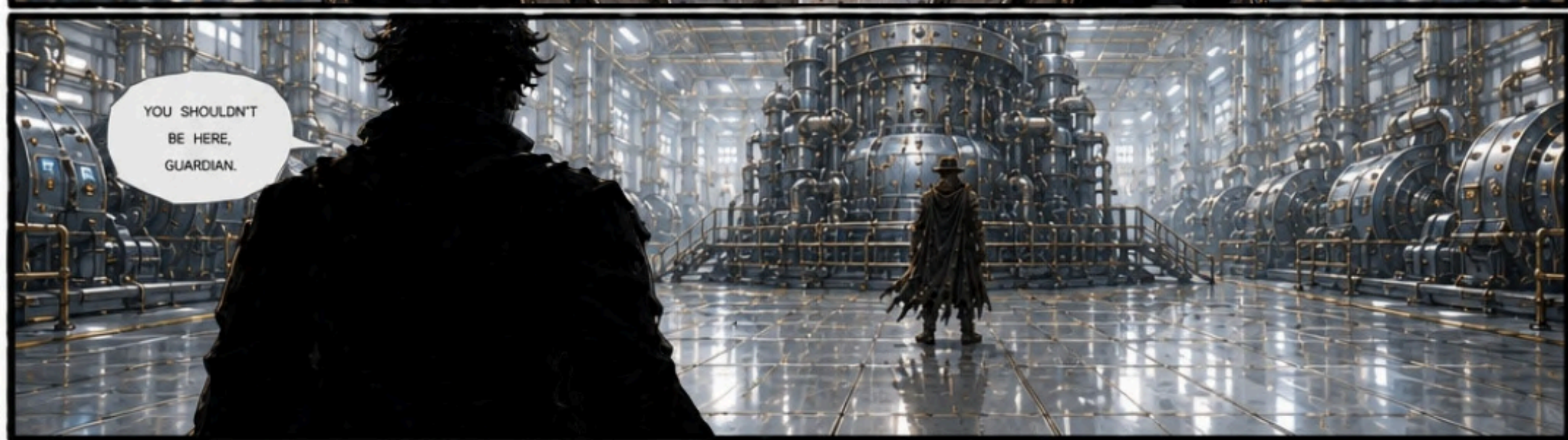
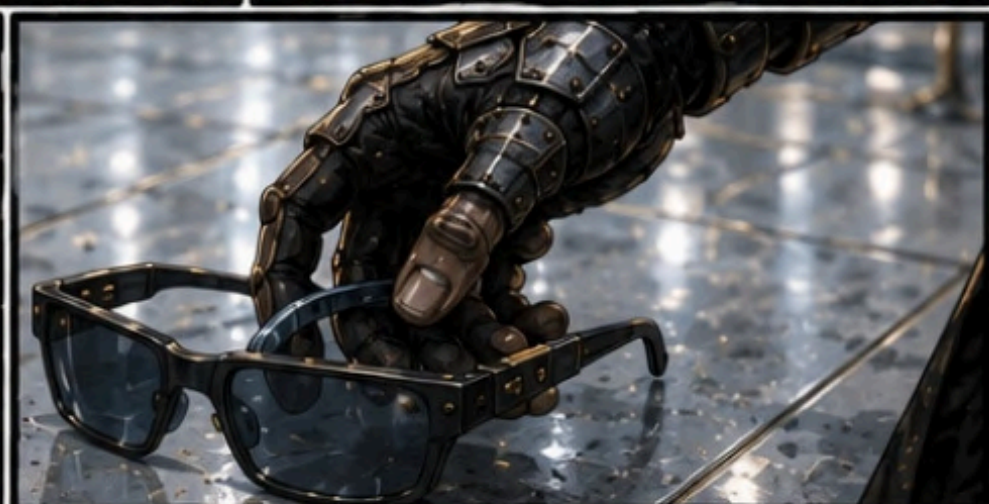
AS YOU WISH. I'M LEAVING. GOODBYE, MOM.

WITH THAT, SHE FLEW OUT OF THE HOUSE WITH TEARS

LEAVING HER FATHER STANDING FROZEN IN SILENCE. HE LOOKED TOWARD THE OPEN DOORWAY, FINALLY REALIZING HOW DEEPLY HIS WORDS HAD HURT HER. HER MOTHER SAID NOTHING EITHER. NEITHER OF THEM KNEW WHAT TO SAY.







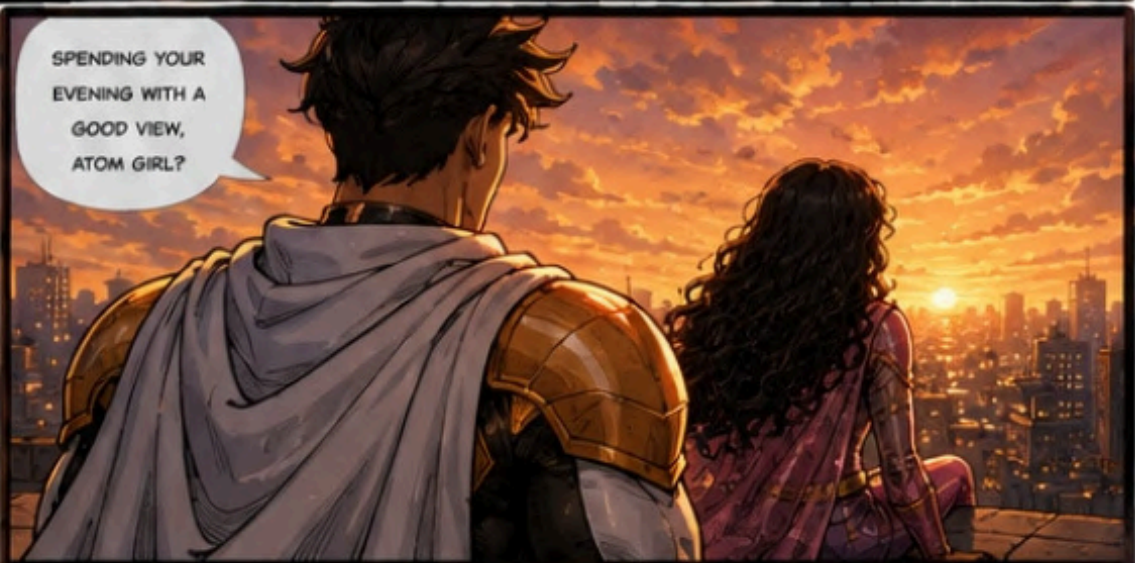


WHY IS HE LIKE THIS?
I'VE DONE EVERYTHING
HE ASKED ME TO DO.
I'VE TRIED TO BECOME
EVERYTHING HE WANTED.
WHY CAN'T I SATISFY HIM?

A GENTLE BREEZE
MOVED THROUGH
MY HAIR.
FOR A MOMENT,
THE CITY FELT
PEACEFUL.



SPENDING YOUR
EVENING WITH A
GOOD VIEW,
ATOM GIRL?



NO, SIR!
JUST THINKING
ABOUT SOMETHING.
DO I NEED TO DO
ANY WORK, SIR?



SIT, GIRL.
AND YOU DON'T
NEED TO CALL
ME SIR.
JUST ALPHA.



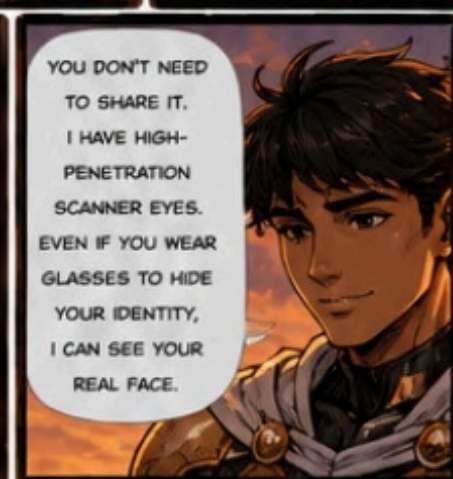
ARE YOU!
OKAY, DARU?



HOW DID YOU
KNOW MY NAME?
I DIDN'T SHARE
IT WITH
ANYONE.



YOU DON'T NEED
TO SHARE IT.
I HAVE HIGH-
PENETRATION
SCANNER EYES.
EVEN IF YOU WEAR
GLASSES TO HIDE
YOUR IDENTITY,
I CAN SEE YOUR
REAL FACE.



I WISH PEOPLE
HAD THAT ABILITY.

PEOPLE?
THAT'S A WEIRD
ABILITY TO HAVE,
ISN'T IT?

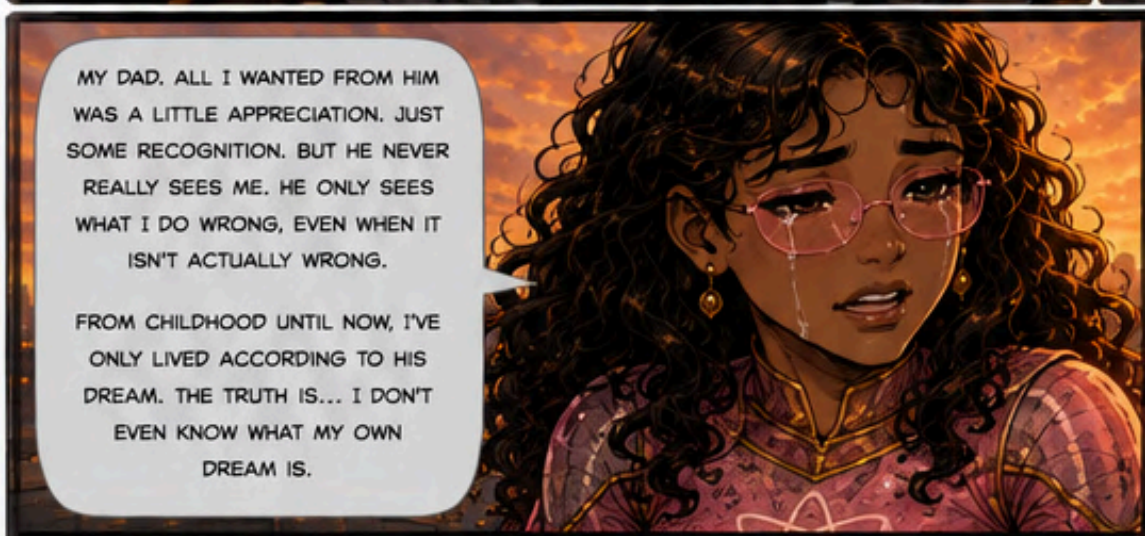
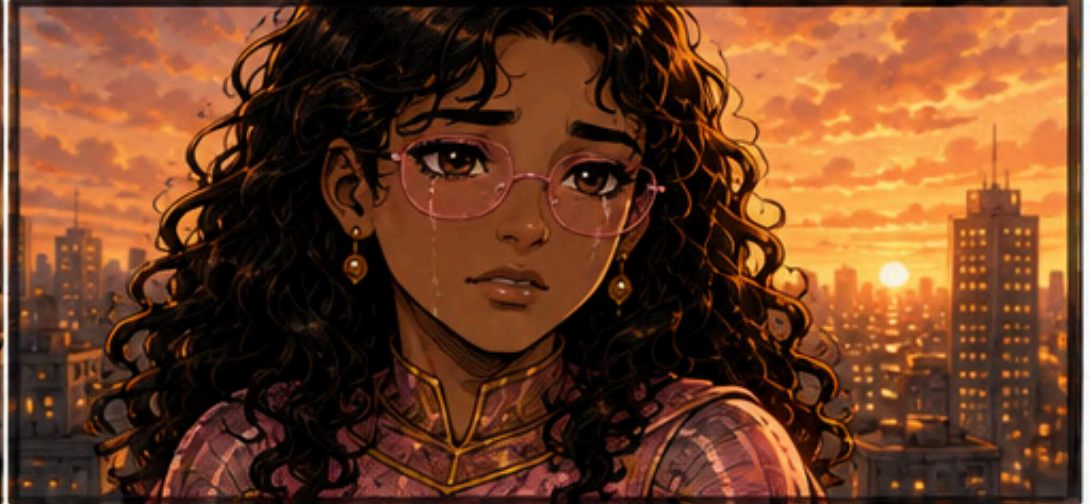


NOT FOR THAT.
I MEAN... TO SEE
THE REAL HEART
OF PEOPLE.
NOT WHAT THEY
CHOOSE TO SHOW.



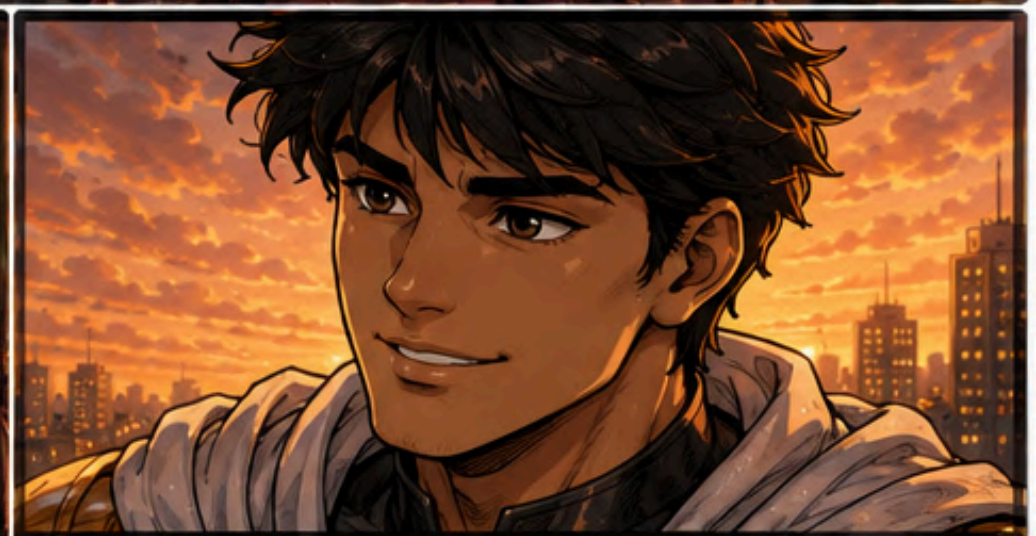


WHAT'S THE
ISSUE, DARU?

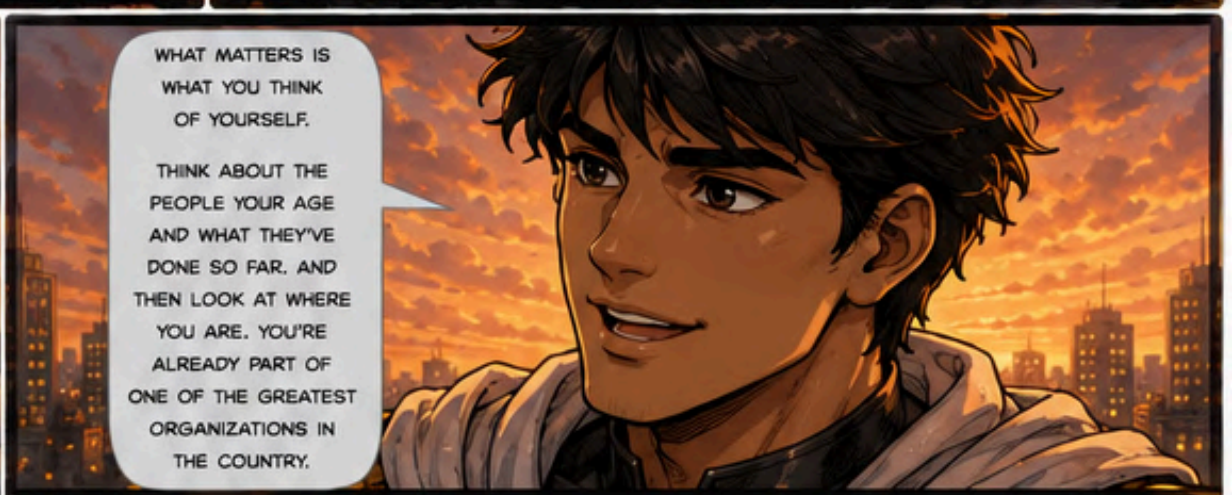


MY DAD. ALL I WANTED FROM HIM
WAS A LITTLE APPRECIATION. JUST
SOME RECOGNITION. BUT HE NEVER
REALLY SEES ME. HE ONLY SEES
WHAT I DO WRONG, EVEN WHEN IT
ISN'T ACTUALLY WRONG.

FROM CHILDHOOD UNTIL NOW, I'VE
ONLY LIVED ACCORDING TO HIS
DREAM. THE TRUTH IS... I DON'T
EVEN KNOW WHAT MY OWN
DREAM IS.

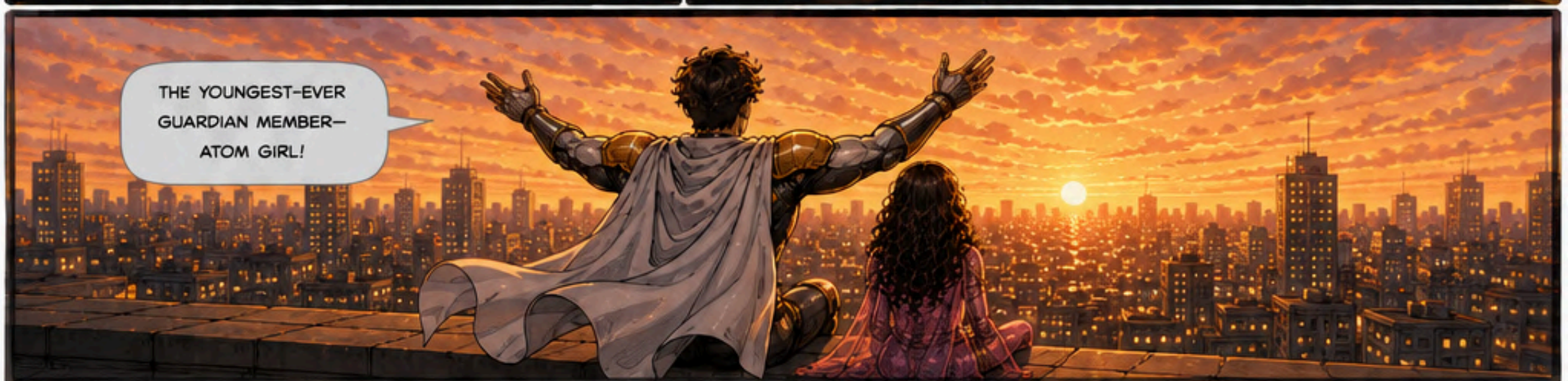


WHY DO YOU NEED
HIS RECOGNITION,
DARU, WHEN YOU'RE
ALREADY SPECIAL?



WHAT MATTERS IS
WHAT YOU THINK
OF YOURSELF.

THINK ABOUT THE
PEOPLE YOUR AGE
AND WHAT THEY'VE
DONE SO FAR. AND
THEN LOOK AT WHERE
YOU ARE. YOU'RE
ALREADY PART OF
ONE OF THE GREATEST
ORGANIZATIONS IN
THE COUNTRY.



THE YOUNGEST-EVER
GUARDIAN MEMBER—
ATOM GIRL!



CLAP!
CLAP!



DO YOU SEE
THAT CLOUD?



THAT'S ALTOSTRATUS. THE SAD THING
ABOUT IT IS THAT IT CAN'T REALLY
SEE THE BEAUTIFUL VIEW OF THIS
PLANET OR THE MASSIVE VIEW OF THE
SKY. THE CLOUDS ABOVE AND BELOW
IT COVER ALMOST EVERYTHING. BUT
IT'S THE ONE PROTECTING THE PEOPLE
BELOW FROM THE DIRECT SUNLIGHT.



THAT'S YOU.

YOU'RE GOING TO DO A GREAT JOB PROTECTING PEOPLE. THERE WILL BE MILLIONS WHO ARE GRATEFUL FOR WHAT YOU DO.

YOU MAY HAVE TO SACRIFICE SOMETHING TO PROVIDE EVERYTHING. THAT'S WHAT HEROES DO.

AND SOMEWHERE ALONG THAT PATH, YOU'LL EVENTUALLY GAIN WHAT YOU'RE DREAMING OF.



NOW TELL ME... ARE YOU A HERO OR NOT?



YES, I AM, SIR... SORRY. ALPHA.

BUT HOW DO YOU KNOW SO MUCH ABOUT THOSE CLOUDS?



AHHHH... HONESTLY? I DON'T.

I FLEW THROUGH ONE ONCE. THAT'S IT. EVERYTHING ELSE WAS JUST A METAPHOR.



DARU!

WHAT WAS THAT?

IT'S HIM.



HA... HELLO, ALPHA. LONG TIME.



TO BE CONTINUED...

